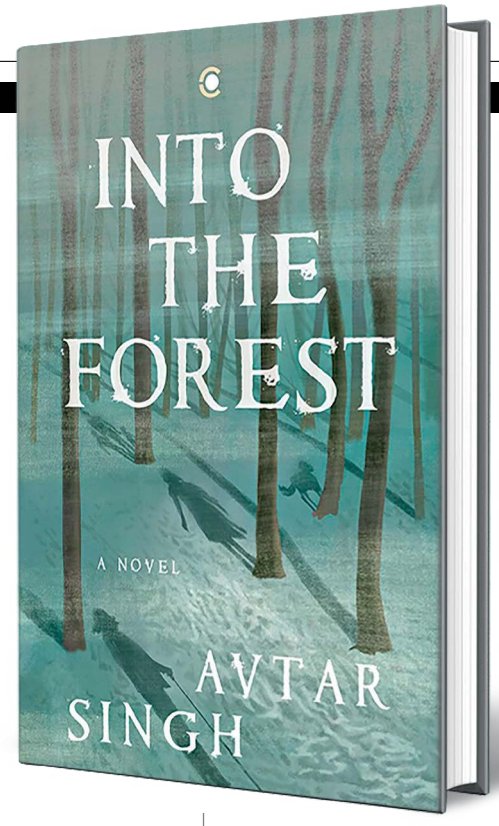
BOOKS

Jungle Book

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INTO THE FOREST: A NOVEL
by Avtar Singh
CONTEXT/WESTLAND BOOKS
₹499; 168 pages

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In the five years since the world woke up to the realities of the Covid-19 era, there has already been a string of brilliant, inquisitive novels about the unique and unprecedented nature of this time. Ali Smith's *Companion Piece*, Louise Erdrich's *Sentence* and Gary Shteyngart's *Our Country Friends* spring to mind as three novels that approach the problem admirably in very different ways. We can now add Avtar Singh's *Into the Forest* to this 'pandemic canon'. Within a svelte 160-odd pages, Singh has crafted a compelling tableau of characters brought together and torn asunder by migration, epidemic and circumstance.

Set in an unspecified small town in Germany during the early days of the pandemic, the book begins when Nabi, a young Afghan refugee and janitor at a local hospital, finds himself under the scanner of suspicion. Mia, a young German woman he had been "sitting too close" with, has disappeared and the town's dormant xenophobic tendencies have surfaced anew (amplified, no doubt, by the paranoia around the new virus). Meanwhile, the forest adjacent to the town becomes a kind of 'liminal space' where the novel's three crucial female characters form an unlikely alliance—Ahilya, increasingly disillusioned by a loveless husband and a distant son, Nejla, a Bosnian woman in an abusive marriage and Liesl, the elder German lady who comes to care for the two younger women the way she tends to her tulips.

Singh is particularly strong while gently probing away at familial relationships—who needs whom, and how often, and how much. He is also similarly wise while contrasting the different kinds of silences in our lives (the trusting, content silence of a pet vs the awkward, stifling silence of a spouse). The novel begins with an epigraph from Angela Carter and she's also name-checked by Ahilya during a conversation. Shortly afterwards, there's a touching moment involving Liesl's husband Uli. He's thinking about his own isolation in a way that wouldn't have been out of place in an Angela Carter fairytale.

"If a giant were to come and pick my house up and shake it, he thinks mordantly, what sort of noise would it make? Would I be the dried-up old seed inside that hits the walls and produces the sound and so sets the room to dancing?"

The question of language is also handled intelligently and used as a way to depict the degradation of communication that happened during the Covid years—enforced silences tend to blunt the sharp edges of one's tongue and brain. When Ahilya apologises to Liesl after asking a question that feels too personal in retrospect, the older lady says it's fine "as long as it's in German". Another awkward question about language prompts Liesl to say, "I grew up in the GDR, what do you think I learnt?" (a reference to the Soviet occupation of East Germany, i.e., GDR).

Through its shifting points of view, its thoughtful dialogue and its expansive humanity, *Into the Forest* presents a memorable story about isolation, loneliness—and the human mind's seductive, dangerous gift for conjuring dreamworlds. ■

–Aditya Mani Jha